

Life Explorer

Week 1 Teacher Guide – Part 1

Expedition: Antarctica • Days 1–3

This guide is written for the parent. Read it once before the day begins. Prep time each day is under 10 minutes.

Day 1 – Launch the Expedition

Today's Big Question

How do explorers learn about places they've never been?

Parent Prep

Set out a globe, the Wonder Wall poster, Explorer Journal, *Sophie Scott Goes South*, sticky notes, colored pencils.

Learning Objectives

Students activate prior knowledge, generate authentic questions, practice oral language, write one sentence, and begin using maps and globes.

Teacher Script

'Today we begin our first expedition. Explorers don't start with answers—they start with questions. By the end of this week, we'll know more about Antarctica than we do today.'

Read Aloud

Read *Sophie Scott Goes South*. Pause only to ask: What do you notice? What surprised you? What would you ask Sophie if she were here?

Wonder Wall

Draw three columns: What I Know, What I Wonder, What I Learned. Record Oliver's words exactly. Resist correcting. Circle three questions to investigate this week.

Skills Block

Reading lesson (20 min). Handwriting: Antarctica, ice, penguin. Life of Fred (20 min).

Create

Draw Antarctica as you imagine it today. Date the picture—you'll compare it on Friday.

Assessment

Can Oliver ask meaningful questions? Is he engaged? What topics seem to excite him?

Teacher Reflection

After the lesson, jot down: What lit Oliver up today? Which questions should guide tomorrow? Which academic skills need a little more practice?

Day 2 – Where Is Antarctica?

Today's Big Question

Where is Antarctica and what makes it unique?

Parent Prep

Gather globe, atlas, *Where Is Antarctica?*, first YouTube video, blue painter's tape.

Teacher Script

'Yesterday we discovered Antarctica exists. Today let's find it.'

Activity

Locate Antarctica on the globe. Find Florida. Trace an imaginary airplane route. Tape a large circle on the floor to represent Earth and let Oliver walk from Florida to Antarctica.

Video

Watch your first selected Antarctica overview video. Pause whenever Oliver asks a question and add it to the Wonder Wall instead of answering immediately.

Writing

Complete: 'Today I learned _____. ' Draw one new thing discovered.

Math Connection

Count continents. Count oceans. Compare which is larger: Antarctica or Florida?

Assessment

Listen for new vocabulary: continent, ocean, South Pole.

Teacher Reflection

After the lesson, jot down: What lit Oliver up today? Which questions should guide tomorrow? Which academic skills need a little more practice?

Day 3 – Penguins & Survival

Today's Big Question

How do penguins survive freezing temperatures?

Parent Prep

Prepare Crisco blubber experiment, bowl of ice water, towels, penguin video.

Teacher Script

'Would you jump into freezing water? Penguins do every day. How?'

Prediction

Have Oliver predict what will happen with a bare hand versus a 'blubber' hand.

Experiment

Complete the Crisco insulation experiment. Keep explanation short: fat helps keep heat in.

Discussion

Ask: What other animals might need blubber? Why don't penguins wear coats?

Build

Use LEGO or recycled materials to create a penguin habitat.

Skills Block

Reading lesson and Life of Fred.

Journal

Draw the experiment. Finish: 'I discovered...'

Assessment

Did Oliver revise his thinking after the experiment? What new questions emerged?

Teacher Reflection

After the lesson, jot down: What lit Oliver up today? Which questions should guide tomorrow? Which academic skills need a little more practice?